

WOW!

The face masks worn by scuba divers make fish and other objects look much bigger and closer than they really are.

CLOSE ENCOUNTERS

Since the invention of the scuba system, divers have seen and photographed many types of marine life that were once known only from dead and dying specimens brought up by fishing lines and nets. Divers have also been able to watch the behavior of these animals, and record it on video. Most of the images of marine life that we see on television have been captured by scuba divers equipped with specialized underwater cameras like the one seen here.



Cylinder holds enough air to last at least 30 minutes



DIVING INTO THE PAST

Scuba diving has also revolutionized underwater archaeology. Ancient cities and shipwrecks are often hidden under layers of sediment, and many have been discovered by amateur scuba divers. Such finds are painstakingly excavated by teams of expert divers using the same basic scuba equipment. The position of every find is recorded by photographs and special underwater drawing techniques before it is taken to the surface. These finds provide a unique insight into the past.

◀ ANCIENT GLASS

A diver works on the Glass Wreck—the remains of a ship that sank off the coast of Turkey in the 11th century with a cargo of glassware on board. Many of the glass jars are still intact.

UNDER THE ICE

Scuba divers have even explored beneath floating polar sea ice, encountering some amazing creatures like this beluga whale. Divers need special protective suits to combat the cold, but since the water temperature can never be lower than freezing point, it's not much colder than any other cold ocean—and warmer than the air above the ice.

